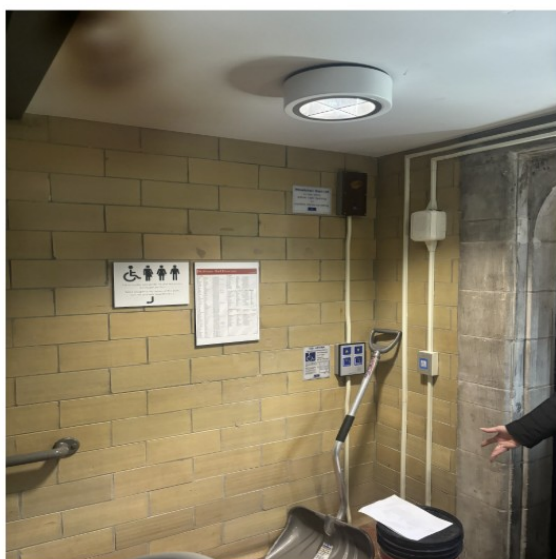


The Cycle of Exclusion

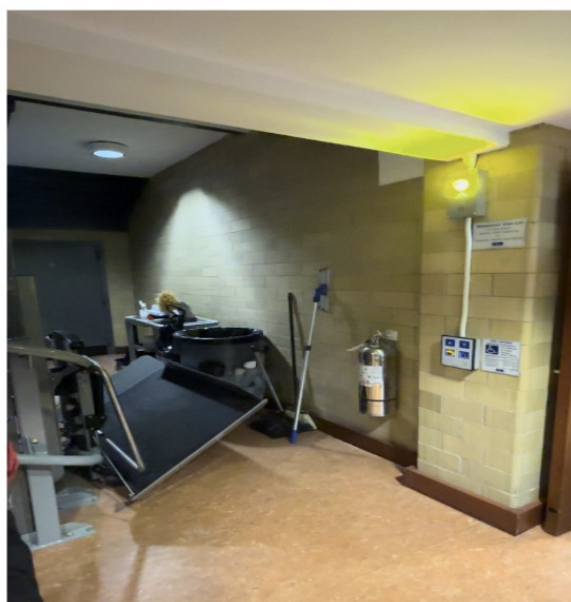
Jeonghyun “Jane” Park

Princeton University is exclusive. Its high selectivity alone makes it one of the most exclusive among many competitive universities in the nation. However, ironically, it also takes great pride in fostering inclusion. The Office of Institutional Equity and Diversity expresses its pride in inclusion of students with disabilities. In the first line of its website it states, “Princeton University is committed to providing access to all individuals” ((Princeton) Policy on Disability & Accessibility). Throughout the site, words like “inclusive,” “accessible,” and “equitable” are repeatedly used emphasizing the university’s recognition of their importance to students with disabilities ((Princeton) Policy on Disability & Accessibility). By promoting a positive image of an accessible campus, Princeton can strengthen the sense of community and reinforce its institutional pride in inclusion. However, the extent to which these commitments translate into tangible experiences for students with disabilities remains a crucial question.

Despite its claims of inclusion, Princeton’s accommodations for students with disabilities can be impractical. For instance, the stair lift in Dickinson Hall, installed for students in wheelchairs, is rarely used. A trash bin obstructs its path, reinforcing the assumption that it is unnecessary. Moreover, the lift’s red flashing lights and loud accompanying sounds create an uncomfortable spectacle for anyone using it. While the university may see these features as essential for safety, they make students more hesitant to use the lift, as it draws unwanted attention to their disabilities. This highlights that accommodation is not about the presence of accessibility features alone. Its effectiveness is not guaranteed if their design discourages use. This raises an important question: is Princeton truly listening to students with disabilities? If so, why do these accommodations remain impractical? How can the university strongly claim its commitment to inclusion when its solutions are not thoughtfully implemented?



Park, Jeonghyun. *Button for the Stair Lift at Dickinson Hall Blocked by Shovel.* 30 Jan. 2025, Princeton Dickinson Hall.



Park, Jeonghyun. *Stair Lift Blocked by Trash Bin.* 30 Jan. 2025, Princeton Dickinson Hall.

Tanya Titchkosky and Sara Ahmed are two scholars who critically examine institutional claims of inclusion. Titchkosky argues that accessibility is often viewed as an “add-on” or mere “accommodation,” rather than a fundamental rethinking of institutional structures (Titchkosky 28). She emphasizes that true inclusion and accessibility require a thoughtful transformation of both perceptions and physical barriers, rather than simply ticking off a checklist with individual accommodations (Titchkosky 35). On the other hand, Sarah Ahmed focuses on the institutional pride of accessibility that can put burden on students who bring up the problem against the pride (Ahmed 158). While their approach is different, both scholars emphasize the need for institutions to move beyond performative gestures and to engage in truly transformative practices rather than maintaining the illusion of inclusion.

These critiques are essential in understanding the ways in which institutions like Princeton, despite their public commitments to inclusion, often fall short in providing meaningful access for students with disabilities. Integrating the work of Titchkosky and Ahmed, this paper will begin by analyzing how Princeton constructs its institutional pride in inclusion. Next, I will explore the impact of this institutional pride. Finally, expanding on their discussion, I will examine how the institution’s pride in inclusion perpetuates itself, making it even more difficult for students with disabilities to challenge the limitations of institutional accessibility.

To understand how institutional pride is created, we should take a closer look at the targeted language Princeton uses to describe the accommodation process. In its accessibility policy, Princeton University asserts its commitment to “[providing] students...with reasonable accommodations ...in a timely manner” (Office of Institutional Equity and Diversity). While this statement looks reasonable, the institution’s reliance on vague terms like “reasonable accommodations” and “timely manner” raises concerns. Such wording allows for broad

interpretation and potential excuses for delays. This ambiguity can lead to policies that, whether intentionally or not, minimize institutional responsibility.

For instance, Hannah Faughnan, a Princeton undergrad, experienced significant delay in accommodation. When Faughnan's disability worsened, she requested a room change, yet it took approximately two months for the university to fulfill her request (Hess). If she were to complain about the delay, Princeton could easily justify its response using its own loosely defined timeline: "[t]he time required for...accommodation will depend on a variety of factors" and "[accommodations will be provided] within forty-five days or as expeditiously as possible" (Office of Institutional Equity and Diversity). By failing to set clear deadlines for itself, the institution retains significant leeway while students remain in a vulnerable position, waiting for necessary support.

In contrast, Princeton's policy employs strict language when outlining student responsibilities: "The student is required to first seek reconsideration by ODS" (Office of Institutional Equity and Diversity). While self-advocacy is important, Princeton's policies create a dynamic where, if something goes wrong, the institution retains flexibility while the student is left to shoulder the blame. Furthermore, the policy grants the University excessive authority, as they may unilaterally dismiss students' complaints deemed "frivolous, not credible, clearly without merit, or outside the scope of these procedures" (Office of Institutional Equity and Diversity). While some degree of discretion in handling cases is inevitable, the policy is worded in such a way that it shifts the responsibility onto students, requiring them to repeatedly justify their needs.

For example, another student at Princeton, Lee, encountered a professor who expected her to conform to a particular stereotype of how a disabled person might look or act (Hess). In this case, Lee had to justify her need for accommodations based on these preconceived expectations, further highlighting how the system places an undue burden on students to prove their disability and the need for support.

Although Princeton's disability policy is ostensibly designed to support students, its language and framework ultimately reinforce a power imbalance between the institution and individual students seeking accommodations. By prioritizing institutional flexibility over student needs, the university risks discouraging students from talking about their needs.

Another way Princeton reinforces unbalanced power dynamics is through its celebration of diversity, particularly by framing disability in a way that appeals to the public. The language used by the institution becomes crucial in this framing. On their website, the AccessAbility Center states that its mission is to "provide opportunities for students to ... envision disability as part of diversity, and understand how difference can enrich... our campus community" (Princeton AccessAbility Center). This statement implies that disabled students offer 'unique perspectives,' reducing individuals to their disabilities, which are framed as the sole source of their uniqueness. Rather than challenging the inequalities disabled students face, this language shifts the burden onto them, as it frames their participation as something to be justified, not inherently valued.

Drawing on Ahmed's concept of justification—where students feel the need to prove their value—students with disabilities at Princeton may find themselves caught in a dilemma. Given that the policy grants the university power to dismiss accommodation requests, these students must not only prove their worth but also justify their need for accommodations. This expectation reinforces the idea that their presence is conditional, requiring constant validation rather than being inherently accepted.

Princeton's use of targeted language in its policies and celebration of diversity actively establishes a power imbalance between the institution and the individual. As a result, students with disabilities are placed in a vulnerable position, forced to continuously advocate for themselves within a system designed to favor the university. Therefore, students with disabilities are, whether intentionally or not, discouraged from speaking up, and as a result, the campus appears to be inclusive. This enables Princeton to construct pride of inclusion when students with disabilities are actually burdened. By controlling the narrative around accessibility with the absence of a student's voice, the university can emphasize its commitment to inclusion.

While the pride stems from the silence of minorities, Princeton proudly emphasizes inclusion in official reports. In the disability services report for undergraduates, terms like “inclusive, accessible, and equitable campus” are frequently used (Fowler et al. 3). However, the inadequate stair lift in Dickinson Hall demonstrates that Princeton's emphasis on accommodation features often lacks thoughtful implementation. Titchkosky critiques this “checklist approach” to accessibility (Titchkosky 76). She argues that simply checking the “Yes” box for the question “Wheelchair Accessible?” does not ensure true usability for students in wheelchairs, as this question overlooks crucial details like the accessibility of the surrounding environment (Titchkosky 35). When the institution attempts to meet only the bare minimum requirement, accommodations become seen as an “add-on” rather than an embedded part of the university's culture.

Moreover, Titchkosky explains that the exclusion of students with disabilities is often justified based on the false notion that disabled people are simply “not present,” when in fact what's missing is not participation, but thoughtful accommodation (Titchkosky 81). Recognizing this flaw in inadequate accommodation would be crucial for institutions like Princeton to provide equal opportunities for students with disabilities. However, the institutional blame often placed on students with disabilities perpetuates the cycle of exclusion, reinforcing the notion that it is the responsibility of disabled students to fit into an inaccessible system.

Bringing attention to these issues could be difficult for students with disabilities. As Ahmed explains, institutional pride of inclusion can take the form of gaslighting—“positivity can make it harder to speak” (Ahmed 156). Coerced positivity, often implemented under the guise of institutional pride, can easily persuade people to overlook the real problems with sweet, reassuring language—“inclusive, accessible, and equitable campus” (Fowler et al. 3). Breaking this peace means challenging everyone who is swayed by the institution's strong pride and belief in its image. Therefore, as Ahmed points out, “bringing a problem to institutional attention can

mean becoming the problem you bring” (Ahmed 147). Disabled students, when advocating for themselves, risk being framed as disruptive to the university's self-image.

Together, Titchkosky and Ahmed demonstrate that the pride institutions take in their inclusivity often works to protect their image while discouraging students with disabilities from advocating for their needs. However, they fail to recognize that institutional pride and discouragement are just a part of a greater cycle that keeps the institution without any improvement. My analysis shows that institutional pride is rooted in targeted language and a lack of consideration of how it discourages students with disabilities. As a result, discouragement and power imbalances become deeply ingrained. Therefore, by presenting a seemingly inclusive campus without addressing students' complaints, institutions can easily shape and maintain their institutional pride. The more the institution clings to its narrative of inclusivity, the more it distances itself from the actual needs of students with disabilities. These students are further discouraged to speak up and excluded in the conversation. The power imbalance grows as the institution's pride in its inclusive image feeds into its ability to shape its own perception. Ultimately, the institution's efforts to protect its image through targeted language and superficial gestures only reinforce exclusion, rather than fostering genuine progress.

This process is especially relevant at a prestigious institution like Princeton, which functions not only as a university but also as a business. Beyond its academic mission, Princeton has a vested interest in maintaining its reputation, securing funding, and attracting top students, faculty, and donors. As Titchkosky points out, institutions often avoid necessary changes when they are seen as inconvenient or misaligned with these broader objectives (Titchkosky 76). In this context, policies and accommodations are often framed not as essential needs but as optional add-ons, implemented only when deemed valuable. When the institution is driven more by its image and efficiency than by a genuine commitment to inclusion and equal opportunity, it can overlook the true needs of students with disabilities. As a result, students are left to navigate an environment that may appear supportive on the surface but is not genuinely equipped to meet their needs. Ultimately, Princeton, operating as a business, prefers inaction unless absolutely necessary. While the institution may take action only when it seems absolutely necessary, the positive feedback loop it creates keeps students' voices unheard, making true inclusion difficult to achieve. The more the institution focuses on maintaining its image and avoiding inconvenience, the less likely it is to engage in meaningful dialogue with those who are marginalized. Without regular, honest feedback from students with disabilities, genuine inclusion is just an elusive goal.

The cycle of exclusion not only discourages students from advocating for their needs but also hinders the university from addressing the real barriers it purports to eliminate, reinforcing the gap between institutional pride and real student experience. To break this cycle, Princeton must move beyond the superficial pride it takes in its image of inclusivity. This will require a genuine commitment to listening to the voices of students with disabilities and investing the necessary resources to ensure a campus environment that goes far beyond simply meeting legal standards. Only through this shift can Princeton achieve true inclusivity, creating a space where all students, regardless of ability, can thrive fully and without barriers.

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